Welcome to the IV LEAGUE

ONCE A MEDICAL NECESSITY, INTRAVENOUS DRIPS ARE NOW BECOMING A WELLNESS FAD—USED AT VITAMIN PARTIES, FOR JET LAG, OR PRE-WEDDING GLOW-UPS. BUT UNREGULATED OVERUSE CAN INVITE DANGER, SAY DOCTORS

By Sonali Acharjee



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For some health conscious youngsters with money to burn, parties have evolved beyond high jinks. At an 'IV drip party' in South Delhi, a group of teenage girls are booked at a five-star hotel suite for their 'Glow & Flow' night. There is soft mood lighting, lavender-scented candles and a flower wall perfect for Instagram selfies. As a licensed nurse inserts IV lines into each guest's arm, they sip cold-pressed juices and pose mid-drip for reels. On the menu are vitamin C, glutathione, magnesium and collagen infusions. All the girls are in coordinated silk robes, as a playlist of lo-fi beats plays in the background. "It's like a beauty sleepover, but with science," an animated 17-year-old Priyanka Malhotra (name changed) quips, though she admits she isn't sure what's in her drip, "but [the last time she took it] it made my skin feel plump for days." The party also set her father back by Rs 3.5 lakh. For the common man, IV drip therapy, or intravenous therapy—a process that administers fluids, medication and nutrients into a person's veins—is used in situations like post-surgery recovery, managing infections, blood transfusions after massive bleeding and during other illnesses. Not any more, for IV therapy is now available on demand, summoned forth to infuse nutrients for better health and appearance.

Ever increasing in popularity, IV nutrient infusions are touted as quick fixes for everything—from fatigue and low immunity to hangovers and post-workout recovery. Some use it for losing weight too. According to market research and consulting firm Grand View Research, the Indian hydration & wellness IV therapy segment was worth around $60.1 million (Rs 524 crore) in 2023 and is expected to touch $112.2 million (Rs 971 crore) by 2030.

The very purpose of IV therapy is to bypass the digestive system and put nutrients directly into the bloodstream, and the new IV infusion therapies can deliver vitamins and minerals in concentrations